GLASSHOUSE

DOWN THE CHUTE



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

Rahul Gandhi's likely coronation as Congress president seems to have hit more roadblocks—losing Punjab and the continuation of a disastrous run in Uttar Pradesh. While Rahul oversaw affairs in Punjab, Priyanka Gandhi was in-charge of Uttar Pradesh. The losses have emboldened the anti-Gandhis factions within the party, who have more reason now to oppose the Gandhi scion's ascent to party presidency. The defeats will also likely impact the party members in Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh who were pinning their hopes on the Gandhi siblings' intervention to replace incumbent CMs Ashok Gehlot and Bhupesh Baghel. In other bad news, Opposition parties now are unlikely to accept a Congress name as their common candidate for the presidential election scheduled in July.

Playing Defence



VIKRAM SHARMA

The observation made by the Bombay High Court on February 27 that NCP chief **Sharad Pawar** had used his influence and clout in the construction of Lavasa, the controversial hill city that came up near Pune in 2009, left him shocked. Anticipating that the BJP would be sure to bring this up, on March 2, Pawar explained his side of the story to 169 legislators at a meeting of the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi. According to a Congress leader, Pawar spent more than half the meeting, which was called to chalk out the ruling alliance's strategy, defending himself. The controversy has certainly put the NCP chief on the back foot.

–Kaushik Deka with Kiran D. Tare, Amitabh Srivastava and Amarnath K. Menon

WHAT'S COOKING?

On March 4, shortly after meeting his Jharkhand counterpart **Hemant Soren** in Ranchi, Telangana chief minister **K. Chandrashekar Rao** confirmed having held a political discussion with him, but claimed it should not be seen as an attempt to build an anti-BJP or anti-Congress front. The Twitter-savvy Soren retweeted some pictures of the meeting, but said nothing of what transpired. Speculation is rife that the meeting was to find consensus on a candidate for the presidential election.



ANI



COALITION ADHARMA

The sweet taste of success that the ruling DMK enjoyed after its thumping victory in the urban local bodies election in Tamil Nadu has turned a bit sour for CM **M.K. Stalin**. He had directed that 94 posts of mayor and deputy mayor, municipal and deputy chairmen, president and vice-president in 21 corporations, 138 municipalities and 489 town panchayats would be for the party's coalition partners, but DMK functionaries got themselves elected instead. After his allies complained that the coalition dharma had been flouted, an angry Stalin directed the rebels to quit, saying, "As a party leader, I feel guilty and ashamed." Those who don't resign face dismissal from the party.

Atmanirbhar Gujarat



Gujarat finance minister **Kanu Desai** has estimated that the Centre's grant to the state will dip by 41 per cent in 2022-23. The state had received Rs 27,178 crore from the Union government in 2021-22. The amount will be Rs 15,982 crore in the next financial year. The reduced central assistance would usually be considered a setback for the state government in an election year, but Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel is planning to claim it as an achievement. The state government says lower grants from Delhi are an indication that Gujarat is becoming less dependent on central funds, which is a sign of a healthy state economy.